NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3♣
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 10 8 ♥ A 2 ♦ K 10 9 ♣ Q J 10 4	
♠ 7 5 2 ♥ Q J 9 4 ♦ 8 5 4 ♣ A 8 5	N W E S	♠ K 6 3 ♥ K 10 6 3 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ 9 7 2
	♠ J 9 4 ♥ 8 7 5 ♦ A Q J 2 ♣ K 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥3

Partner has about 11 points and he has no 4-card Major suit.

He thinks 3NT would be a good spot. You have no reason to disagree so you pass.

North plays 3NT; East leads the ♥3.

West plays the ♥J and you duck, hoping he will switch to any other suit! But of course he doesn't; he continues with the ♥4.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 6

You need three more winners. You can get them in ♣s by just driving out the ♣A. The danger is that EW might win the ♣A and 4 ♥ tricks. Or, you can get them in ♠s if West holds the ♠K, a 50% chance.

You should try to avoid 50% chances when you have something better. Consider the chance that EW will actually be able to win 4 ♥ tricks if you give them the lead with the ♣A. In particular notice that you were dealt the ♥2! If East's ♥3 is a fourth down lead then he cannot have anything smaller and the ♥s are splitting 4-4.

Knowing they can only take 3 ♥ tricks makes it safe for you to drive out the ♣A.

So win the ♥A and drive out the ♣A. They will take their 2 ♥ tricks next. If West then leads a ♠ **DO NOT FINESSE**. Take your nine tricks and run.

The question to consider about this Deal is whether to trust your opponents, in particular whether you can trust them to be leading fourth highest.

While the answer may depend on the opponent, usually you should take their opening lead at face value. After all, their main goal is to give information to their partner, not to deceive you.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 9 7 4 ♥ J 10 4 3 ♦ J 7 6 ♣ 10 8	
♠ 8 ♥ A K 8 6 5 2 ♦ K 10 3 ♣ J 7 4	N W E S	♠ A 6 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ A K Q 6 2
	♠ Q J 10 5 2 ♥ Q ♦ A 9 5 2 ♣ 9 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

Who knows whether you should use a transfer or just bid 4♥ yourself. Assume you decide on the transfer and bid 2♦. Partner bids 2♥ (of course).

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Naturally you go ahead and bid 4♥, the final contract.

The contract would be 4♥ played by West.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠Q and North follows with the ♠9.

You win the first trick with the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The loser count is very confused, but that ♣ suit is not confused at all. You want to be able to run the ♣s so your plan is to play the ♥ A K, and if both defenders follow go ahead and knock out the last ♥ so they can't ruff your ♣ tricks.

Unfortunately when you play ♥ A K, South plays the ♥Q, then discards a ♠.

You may think you should change your plan but you should go right ahead with it. North has two master trumps, but dummy still has 4 small ones. So play a ♥ to force out North's ♥10. He will no doubt play another ♠ and force dummy to ruff. No problem, knock out North's final ♥ and dummy will still have one tiny trump left. When you get back in you can run the ♣s unimpeded.

Usually it is good technique to leave master trump(s) undrawn.

The exception is when you have a long suit you wish to run and you can't stand to have the running stopped by a ruff.

This Deal is unusual in that there are two master trumps, but the principle is the same.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 2
♥ Q 9
♦ J 7 3
♣ J 9 8 6 3 2

♠ K 10 6
♥ J 10 7 6
♦ A 6 5
♣ Q 7 5



♠ Q J 9 5 3
♥ K 4 3
♦ K 8 2
♣ 10 4

♠ A 7 4
♥ A 8 5 2
♦ Q 10 9 4
♣ A K

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♣
All Pass			

3♣ by South
Lead: ♥J

The 2♠ bid is used as a transfer to 3♣.

If you don't use this in your system, just consider this hand; you might decide to incorporate it. So you bid 3♣ and everybody passes.

South plays 3♣. West leads the ♥J.

You play dummy's ♥Q hopefully, but East plays the ♥K.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

That is one loser too many. The ♣Q MIGHT drop . . . but she won't. There are no finesse positions. So you are going to have to establish a winner somewhere to discard dummy's small ♠.

Do you see it? The ♥8. Take the ♥A. Then play your ♣ A K. As predicted, the ♣Q doesn't fall. Then play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9. Of course West will take the ♥10, but now your ♥8 is high.

As soon as you get the lead you play the ♥8 and discard dummy's ♠2.

We know, you didn't really play the ♥Q on the first trick in the hope that West had underled the ♥K (although he certainly might have done so).

The real reason for covering was so you could establish the ♥8 by force.

Suppose you had not played the ♥Q to trick one. East would have withheld the ♥K and you'd have had to take your ♥A. Later East would have taken dummy's ♥Q with his ♥K, then played a small ♥ through your ♥8 to West's ♥ 10 7.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 9 6 4 ♥ K 6 5 2 ♦ 10 7 ♣ Q J 10 3	
♠ Q 10 8 5 ♥ A Q 7 ♦ K Q 9 2 ♣ A 6		♠ A K J 7 3 ♥ 8 4 3 ♦ A 5 4 ♣ K 9
	♠ 2 ♥ J 10 9 ♦ J 8 6 3 ♣ 8 7 5 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♥	Pass
3♠	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

6♠ by West
Lead: ♣Q

You could either use a transfer or you could jump to 3♠. You decide on the transfer and bid 2♥. Partner jumps to 3♠!

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The 3♠ bid is a "Super-accept", showing a maximum 1NT opener, 4 ♠s and a doubleton. In other words, partner's hand has revalued to 18 points. So you bid 6♠ (or you could ask for Aces instead).

The contract would be 6♠ played by East.

West plays 6♠. North leads the ♣Q, South follows with the ♣2.

You win the first trick with the ♣A in your hand.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

There are two obvious possibilities for avoiding the ♥ loser. You could finesse South for the ♥K; this is a 50% chance. The ♦s could split 3-3; this is a 36% chance.

In fact, your chances are better than either of those percentages because you can try the ♦s first, and if they **DON'T** split you can then try the ♥ finesse.

Pull trumps; North shows up with 3 trumps. Play the ♦K, then a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. On this trick North follows with the ♦10.

Your contract just became a sure thing! Play the ♣K to strip both your hands of ♣s. Lead dummy's last ♦, and when South plays low, finesse the ♦9. If the finesse wins, discard a ♥ from dummy on your good ♦. But if the finesse loses to North's ♦J, he will be endplayed and have to lead a ♥ into your ♥ A Q or give you a ruff/sluff with a ♣. And on top of that your fourth ♦ will be good.

In this actual Deal your ♦ finesse worked which gave you 4 ♦ tricks.

But imagine that the ♦J is transposed to the North hand. He wins that ♦ trick but must give you the contract with his return.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 6 ♥ A 10 3 ♦ A 8 2 ♣ 10 9 7 4	
♠ J 10 5 4 ♥ 8 4 ♦ J 10 9 6 ♣ J 8 2	N W E S	♠ Q 9 2 ♥ K Q J 9 7 5 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ 6
	♠ 8 7 3 ♥ 6 2 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ A K Q 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥K

Partner's jump to 3NT is a lebensohl method.

He is describing a hand with which he would have bid 3NT if there had been no overcall. But he is warning you that he **DOES NOT HAVE** a ♥ stopper!

Since you **DO** have a ♥ stopper you decide to pass and play 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥K.

You hold up your ♥A until the third round.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 7

You need two more winners. Barring a 4-0 ♣ split your two extra winners will be the ♣5 and ♣3.

So after winning the ♥A, you play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit.

UhOh. Surely you didn't play your ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q???

If you did then just look at the situation now. If the ♣J doesn't fall on the next trick the suit will be blocked. Now go back in time and play the ♣10 to dummy's ♣Q.

That's better. Now under the ♣ A K you can unblock the ♣ 9 7, which will leave you with the ♣4 to slip under dummy's ♣5.

Watch those spot cards. You may have to unblock them to stay in the hand you want to be in.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ Q 9 8 5 3 2 ♦ Q 10 ♣ A J 6 3	
♠ K Q J 9 5 3 ♥ K J 7 ♦ 6 2 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ A 4 2 ♥ A 6 ♦ A J 8 4 3 ♣ Q 7 2
	♠ 10 8 7 ♥ 10 4 ♦ K 9 7 5 ♣ K 10 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♣10

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You are nowhere near strong enough to be thinking of slam so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by West.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♣10. North wins the ♣A. They continue ♣s and you ruff the third one in dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

Those losers are based on dummy's hand, not yours. You can figure them either way but it is usually easier to determine losers based on the long-trump hand. It's important to remember it in this Deal because the zero losers in ♥s assumes you will ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Pull one round of trumps with dummy's ♠K. Both defenders follow suit. Play the ♥A, then ♥6 to dummy's ♥K. On this trick South follows with the ♥10.

The Plan is still the same, you will ruff the ♥ in your hand, but you better be sure to ruff with your ♠A. Aha! Your precaution pays off when South shows out of ♥s, but of course he cannot over-ruff your ♠A.

A very good Bridge maxim is this:When you are ruffing, ruff with as high a trump as you can afford.

Here, with only 2 trumps left out, you can afford the ♠A.